

The background is a dark, atmospheric landscape painting. In the foreground, a stone wall runs across the middle ground. To the left of the wall is a tall, rectangular stone pillar. A wavy line is drawn on the pillar, ending in a small red dot. At the base of the pillar, there are several coins and a small white bone. In the middle ground, two sheep are grazing in a field of tall, dry grass. In the background, there are rolling hills under a dark, cloudy sky with a small, glowing orb (the sun or moon) visible. The overall color palette is dark and moody, with shades of brown, grey, and black, accented by the red dot and the glowing orb.

# Vraska

## Lord of Blood and Bone

A teaching treatise for the instruction of temple students

Front cover: Shrine to Kéruzh, near an unnamed village in northern central Tsolyánu.  
As sketched and later coloured by the author.

Art by Gemini AI - Nano Banana 2

# Vraska, Lord of Blood and Bone

*“He Who Returns All Things”*

The Seventy-Third<sup>1</sup> Aspect of Sárku, the Lord of Worms,  
by the reckoning of the Púrdimal schools.

## On the Place of the Worm Beneath the Furrow in the Theology of Sárku

A teaching treatise for the instruction of temple students

For circulation among the temple schools

Attributed to the Kusijáktodali, Nriséshu hiRayástqa of the Triangular Monolith Clan,  
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Written during the reign of the Emperor Hirkáne,  
The Stone upon Which the Universe Rests, 2348 AS.

Translated into English from the Original Tsolyáni by

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## The Heads of the Argument

Here are set down the heads of the argument which follows, that the student may know beforehand what he is to be told, and his teacher what he is to be examined upon.

**Preface.** Of the author, his standing, and why a servant of Change should write upon an Aspect of the Worm Lord. With the stone at the village east of Púrdimal, which contains the whole of the argument and may be understood in place of it.

**I. Of the three dominions.** That growth belongs to the Lady of Blue Skies; that the Báletl belongs to Lord Belkhánu and to His Cohort Lord Qón; and that the corpse and the matter of it belong to Lord Sáрку. That Vráska stands within the third dominion and nowhere else. With the question of the barber's sweepings, which the schools at Thri'íl have argued for two centuries without profit.

**II. Of what it is to return.** That Change is the condition of the universe and not an interruption of it. That the corpse is not at rest but in motion. That the farmer observes in his yard what the tomb teaches at considerably greater expense.

**III. Of the Fivefold and the letter.** That death, earth, filth, sorrow, and decay are an order and not a heap of unpleasant words. That Vráska gathers the first four and leaves the fifth standing, which is the proof that he is the Worm Lord's and has not been borrowed from a kinder god. That the farmer at his heap stands already in the posture the temple prescribes, though no one has taught it him.

**IV. Of Kéruzh in the villages.** That the rural observance is old, keeps no temples, and marks its stones in Lord Sáрку's own colours with Lord Sáрку's own sign. That its strength lies among the clans of the plough, both the low and the high. That the devotion of villagers is a series of arrangements with whoever has charge of the matter in hand and is not a loyalty.

**V. Of the Five Gifts.** The Green, the Brown, the Red, and the White, which are given by us; and the Black, which is returned to us, and from which the epithet is taken. With the difficulty of the Brown Gift, which is given by the living. And a caution against the correspondence which some press upon the Fivefold, and which someone will carve upon a wall before I am dead.

**VI. Of Vráska and the Lady.** That he is no god of fertility, and that the objection of Avánthe's priests upon this point is just. With the matter of the two shrines at Nrashké, upon which I have perhaps said more than the argument required.

**VII. Of Whose Aspect He is.** That the priests of Lord Durritlámish claim decay by way of Bázh Akhár, and that their claim is serious and is answered by the direction of the work. That the Inner Temple of Lord Sáрку holds the villages an embarrassment, and that neither temple desires the worshippers whose jurisdiction both desire. That the question is one about temples and not about gods, who keep no offices and do not consult our registers.

**VIII. Of the three understandings.** The peasant's, which is practical and is correct. The Worm Lord's priest's, which is dark and is distant. The scholar's, which is uncomfortable, and is meant to be.

**IX. Of Observances.** Seven common forms, being neither commandments nor liturgy; and what a student deserves who recites them at a farmer as though they were.

**X. Of objections, with answers.** Seven in number. Of these the third, concerning the promise of endurance held out to the elect, is the only one the student need fear, and he should not go into a village without an answer to it.

**XI. Of what is proposed.** That the observance be taught in the temple schools as what it is, under the usual disciplines. That the reasons are practical before they are theological. And that in this instance instruction has travelled upward, our part in the business having been to arrive late and argue about the filing.

**XII. Propositions for the student.** Ten in number, to be held in memory. With notes for the examining priest, which the student is not to read, and will.

**Authors Notes.** Six, upon the numbering of the Aspects, the author's own standing, the distribution of the name, the Five-Sided Tome, an objection I decline to entertain, and a scholar I decline to name.

**Appendix.** Names, epithets, colours, and sign; with a caution against taking any of them for universal.

## Preface: Of the Author and His Purpose

Some years ago, travelling east from Púrdimal in the dry season, I stopped at a village whose name I did not trouble to learn and sat down in the shade of a dung heap, this being the only shade on offer. Beside the heap stood a stone about the height of my knee. Its base was painted brown and its crown whitened, and down its face someone had scratched a wavy line with a daub of red clay at the lower end. I had seen that sign every day of the four years I spent at the City of Sárku: on robes, on lintels, on the copper ornaments of the Worm Lord's priests. I did not expect to find it scratched on a stone beside a heap of chlén dung by a man who had never entered a temple of the Inner Circles in his life. When I asked whose stone it was, he told me it was Kéruzh's and seemed surprised that I had to ask.

That is the whole of my purpose set out in one image, and a man who understands the stone may stop reading here.

For those who continue: it will be asked why a priest of Hrü'ú concerns himself with an Aspect of Sárku, and why a senior-ranking scholar<sup>2</sup> of the Eighth Circle should spend his season of leave writing about manure. The question is a fair one and I will answer it twice.

The first answer is proper to our Dark Trinity. Lord Hrü'ú and Lord Sárku are not allies in the way that men are allies, since no god follows the will of another except as it suits Him\*, and the temples that serve Them are bound by interest rather than affection. But the doctrines touch, and where they touch there is work for a scholar. I make no claim upon the Worm Lord's mysteries. I claim only the right to observe where His teaching and ours illuminate one another, which is a right the temple schools of Béy Sú have exercised for six hundred years without anyone taking offence, or at least without anyone saying so.

The second answer is proper to me. I am a servant of Change, and I have found no clearer demonstration of Change anywhere in the Five Empires than a heap of rotting straw. Students come to us expecting the Mysteries, and are disappointed to be set to watch a compost heap for a season. They should not be. The heap will teach them

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\* *Translator's note.* The author reserves the honorific pronoun for the gods and the Greater Aspects, and I have given it a capital in English. Vráska he does not so honour.

more about the relations of Change, coincidence, reality, and unreality than a year of argument in a cool room.

A warning before I begin. I do not intend to make the adherents of Lord Sárku comfortable. His dominion is not a pleasant one and this Aspect of His is not a kindly gardener. What Vráska receives is often foul and sometimes terrible, and a doctrine is not improved by being made agreeable to those who would rather not think about it.

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The farmer knows what Kéruzh does.  
The priest of Sárku knows what Vráska is.  
It is left to the scholar to work out why.

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## I. The Three Dominions

The first error to correct is the common one, heard even in the lower circles, that Lady Avánthe and Lord Sárku are rivals contending over the same ground. They are not, or not over the field. That the Worm Lord stands with ours against the Stable Cycles the Lady keeps is known to every acolyte of both temples, but that quarrel concerns the end of all things, and a field of dná is not the end of anything. Nor, as is sometimes taught carelessly in the villages, do the two divide the world between them. There are three dominions here, not two, and the student who cannot recite all three should not be allowed near a farmer.

The Lady of Blue Skies has charge of fertility, of growth, of the living thing while it lives. The Báletl, the spirit-soul of a man, belongs to Lord Belkhánu and to His Cohort Lord Qón, who conduct it upon its pilgrimage through the Planes of the Afterlife. This is not Lord Sárku's business, and He does not claim it. Any villager who tells you that the Worm Lord eats souls has been listening to his grandmother.

What is left is the corpse, the grave, the process of decay, and the Change of all things into putrefaction and dust, and this is the dominion of Lord Sárku. The dust does not lie idle. It is taken up again by the Weaver of Skeins and woven into further Fabric, which is a matter for another treatise and a better scholar than I.

Vráska stands within the third dominion and nowhere else. Fix this now and much of what follows is easy.

Consider: a man's hair is cut and swept from the floor of the barber's stall. Whose is it? It was living and is not, yet no man died. The schools at Thri'il have argued this for two centuries and the argument is not foolish, though the answer they reach is.

## II. What It Means to Return

We teach that Change is the condition of the universe, and that what men call settlement is an illusion produced by the shortness of their lives. A wall seems permanent to the man who built it; the mountain behind it has seen a great many walls. Our brothers of the Supreme Principle of Stability have raised an entire doctrine upon the wall's estimation of its own permanence, and they have raised it in stone, which I have always thought splendidly candid of them. I have used this figure in lectures for twenty years and it has not failed me yet, though a student at Tsurú once asked me what the mountain thought of mountains, and I sent him to the library.

Lord Sárku's doctrine is unusually instructive on this point, and I say so as one who has heard His priests put it better than we do. As they teach it, the corpse is in motion from the hour of death, only more slowly than the living can easily see. The grave receives the dead into a process: flesh softens, the fluids go, the worm arrives and does its work, and bone dries and cracks until at length it can no longer be told from the earth around it. The man is gone, but what he was made of has gone nowhere. It has only become something else.

The farmer sees the same thing in his yard and needs no lecture to understand it. His straw heap sinks by a hand's breadth in a month. The leaves he rakes into a corner darken and fall in on themselves, fruit left lying softens into the ground it fell on, and dung heats, settles, and blackens until in time it can be carried back to the field. The ignorant call this destruction. A student of ours who uses the word in my hearing is sent to the stables for a month to watch destruction fail to occur. None has yet come back unconvinced, though several have come back unwell.

This is why the Aspect interests me. In Vráska, the Worm Lord's understanding of death and our understanding of Change run alongside one another for a considerable distance without becoming the same thing, like the roads to Mrelú and Mekú out of Púrdimal that share a ditch for half a day's walk before they part.

### III. The Fivefold and the Letter

Lord Sárku's number is five: the count of His worm-heads, and the count of the things bound to Him, which are death, earth, filth, sorrow, and decay. Students arrive expecting five unpleasant words heaped together for effect and are disappointed to find them arranged. Earth receives. Filth is matter that has passed out of the condition in which it was useful. Death ends a state. Decay is the working that follows, and it is slower or faster according to the weather and the season, but it does not decline to happen. Sorrow is what is felt by those left standing, who understand that what was is now what is not.

Vráska gathers the first four into a single image a farmer can hold in his hand. The fifth he does not dissolve, and this is the proof that the Aspect is genuinely Sárku's and has not been quietly borrowed from a kinder god. A man may value his compost heap and still grieve the hmélu buried at the field's edge. Both are true at once. Any doctrine that removes the grief has stopped being Sárku's doctrine and has become agriculture.

I note one further thing and make nothing of it. To harmonise with the Worm Lord a man is instructed to look upon a skull in a room floored with earth, holding the god's letter, which is *Ch*, in his mind and mouth. Consider the farmer, standing on bare earth, with the bones of last year's beast in the heap before him. He has not been taught the practice. He is nonetheless standing in it.

### IV. Kéruzh of the Villages

The name Kéruzh is heard throughout the central and northern provinces of Tsolyánu and I have heard it as far east as the fringes of the Kraá Hills and Aukésa<sup>3</sup>. Its origin cannot be fixed to any one place, nor its age to any century. But the traditions are old enough that no one now alive invented them, and I have seen the wavy line on stones

that were already weathered when the village beside them was rebuilt after its last ditlána.

I should say how I came by what follows, since a student is entitled to know and will not be told by anyone else. I have visited nineteen villages in which the name is used, over four seasons of leave in the last eleven years, together with two market towns where I spoke with farmers who had come in to sell. I have kept no notes in the field beyond what my slave could carry, which is less than I should have liked. Eleven of the nineteen lie within five days of Púrdimal, and I am conscious that this is too many from one quarter. I had intended to go west into the Chákas, where I am told the observance differs in at least two particulars, and did not, the roads in the wet season being what they are and my temple having posted me to Béy Sú. What follows is therefore northern, and chiefly of the Púrdimal area, and the student should hold it loosely wherever it claims to be general.

The cult keeps no temples. What it keeps is a stone, or a post, or a marked place, set near the manure heap, the composting ground, the slaughter yard, or the boundary of a field. The offerings are not lavish and are not intended to be. A handful of the first spreading. A little copper pressed into the earth at the stone's foot, which the pious leave and the poor come back for. In many villages the acknowledgement is made in the evening at the rising of Ületl, though I doubt one farmer in twenty could tell you why that hour and not another, and fewer still that every temple of the Worm Lord in the Empire keeps the same hour.

Now attend to the stone itself, because the stone is my strongest argument and I would rather the student took it from me than found it later and thought me careless.

The colours are brown and white: the brown of grave earth and the white of bone, which are the Worm Lord's own colours and are worn by His clergy in every temple in the Empire. The mark is a wavy line with a red circle or daub at one end, which is the Worm Lord's own symbol and signifies the Eternal Victory of the Worm. These villagers have no temple, no schooling, and in most cases no letters. They are nonetheless painting Lord Sáрку's colours on His own sign and setting it beside a dung heap.

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No priest taught them this.

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There is no priest of the Worm Lord within two days' walk of that village, and there has been none in living memory. Whatever the Inner Temple wishes to conclude about the standing of this cult, it cannot conclude that the peasants are worshipping something else and have got there by accident.

Where the worship is strongest, it is strongest among particular clans. The Black Earth and the Copper Plough are the two I know best, being low and very low respectively, and neither will thank me for the notice. The Copper Plough take their name from the metal of the Worm Lord, as they will tell you at length if you let them. Higher up, among clans of standing that are also clans of the plough, the Domed Tomb, the Glory of the Worm, and the Tsárdali all keep observances of the same shape, conducted rather more quietly and with better pottery.

I have said the worship is strongest among the clans of the plough. That is true and it is not the whole of it. Much of the labour of the northern fields is done by those who have no clan at all, and it is they who carry the Gifts. The farmer prays at the sowing; the slave spreads the heap, opens the beast, and gathers the bone.

Weigh the consequence. Every other observance in the Empire asks something before it will admit a man: a clan to stand behind him, a fee, a priest. Vráska asks nothing. A slave may acknowledge the stone as he passes and has given the god the whole of what the god requires. I know of no other Aspect of which that can be said. In the Worm Lord's deeper rites a slave is more often the offering than the one who makes it.

I spoke to none of the slaves. I spoke to farmers, who told me what was done in their fields.

One caution, and it is the caution most often neglected by scholars who have never lived in a village. Do not imagine that a man who leaves an offering for Kéruzh is therefore a worshipper of Lord Sárku, or that he has chosen the Worm Lord over the Lady. He has chosen nothing. He prays to Avánthe before he sows because it is Her business to make things grow, he acknowledges Kéruzh when he spreads the heap because that is Kéruzh's business, he will pay a priest of Thúmis to name his child and give a coin to Lady Dlamélish's dancers at the festival because everyone does. The devotion of the villages is not a single loyalty. It is a series of arrangements with

whoever has charge of the matter in hand, and the man who understands this will govern such people far better than the man who arrives expecting congregations.

Need brings a man to the stone more often than doctrine does. At a village of the Copper Plough two days north of Púrdimal, a farmer told me that he had passed the stone at the end of his yard every day for thirty years and troubled it no further than the spreading. Then came a year in which his heap would not heat. It lay cold and sour through the whole of the dry season, and the field he had meant to bring back with it stayed as poor as it was. He did not go to the Lady, since it is not Her business, nor to a priest, since there was none. He went to the stone with a hmá kid and more copper than he could afford, and went again every evening at the rising of Ületl until the heap turned. He did not claim that Kéruzh had turned it. He said only that he was not going to take the chance. He had need of the Aspect long before any of us had described it, which is the order in which these things generally happen, whatever the registers say.

In some districts nothing is spread upon the fields during the Nine Poison Days of Fésru. In others the spreading is done then deliberately. Both practices are defended by their holders as the ancient one. What would you need to know to decide between them, and is the question even worth deciding?

## V. The Five Gifts

For teaching I recommend the following scheme. It is not liturgy. I have heard four of the terms used by village priests in three districts and the fifth I have heard only twice, which may mean it is rare or may mean I have not travelled enough. I have set them out as five because five is the number, and a scheme that will not sit in the god's own number has been badly made.

**The Green Gift.** Leaves, stems, straw, spent crops, fallen dlél, the roots and haulms of the dná after the harvest is taken. This is the Gift the farmer fears least, because he watches it turn every year and has never known it fail.

**The Brown Gift.** Dung, chiefly of the chlén, the hmá, and the hmélu, and the sweepings of the byre. The Brown Gift raises a difficulty I will not conceal, since it is

better met here than across a table from a priestess of the Lady. Dung is given by the living. Nothing has died to produce it. On what ground, then, does it belong to the Lord of Worms rather than to the Lady whose beasts produced it? The village priests, when pressed, answer that the dung has died even if the beast has not, being matter cast out from the living body and no longer of it. I find this answer better than it first appears.

**The Red Gift.** Blood, and the soft remains of the slaughter yard. It is the Gift at which visitors from the cities grow pale. Blood is the living beast's while it runs in him. Once shed it has begun its return. Slaughter waste therefore carries two meanings at once: the evidence of a death, and the material of a renewal, and whoever carries the bucket out, which in most households is a slave, is not troubled by holding both.

**The White Gift.** Bone and ash, and whatever hard substance remains when the soft substance has gone. This is the most plainly the Worm Lord's of the five. Bone endures, which is why it carries the weight it does in the rural understanding. It is the last thing to argue with Change, and it loses.

**The Black Gift.** The dark, rich, crumbling earth into which the other four resolve. Here the student must be exact, for this is the point on which the whole Aspect turns and the point on which the epithet rests. The first four Gifts are ours. We give them. The Black Gift is not ours and we do not give it. It is returned to us, and the Aspect is named He Who Returns All Things for that reason and no other.

The Prologue to *The Book of Rust-Brown Glimmerings*, which every priest of the Worm can recite, has it that “*each returns to Him in the end, and this is the True Beginning.*” The villages have taken the second half of that sentence more seriously than the temple has.

That the Gifts number five, and that five is Lord Sárku's number, has not escaped the village priests. Some of them press the correspondence further and match each gift to one of the Fivefold: the Red to death, the Brown to filth, the Green to decay, the White to sorrow, the Black to earth. The student will encounter it. I do not recommend it. It is tidy, it can be made to work only by shoving, and the neatness of a thing is poor evidence of its truth. Someone will nonetheless carve it on a wall within my lifetime.

## VI. Vráska and the Lady

On this a man must be precise, because it is the point at which imprecision gives offence to a temple that has done nothing to deserve it.

Avánthe gives fertility, growth, and abundance. Vráska does not. He does not make the seed swell, he does not bring the rain, he does not raise the stalk. His work begins at the far end, when what has lived passes out of its condition into another. The two may be honoured in the same hour by the same man without confusion, and are. A priest of Avánthe who objects to Vráska being called a god of fertility is entirely in the right and the objection should be conceded at once and without sulking. He is not one.

The Lady gives the harvest; the Worm gives the field its memory.

The distinction is one of direction. Avánthe faces the emergence of life. Vráska faces the return of what life leaves behind. A field serves both and belongs to neither, and a shrine is not made Avánthe's by standing in Her weather.

I will give one case at length, since the student will meet the situation far more often than he will meet the doctrine. At Nrashké, in the district south of Púrdimal, an Avánthe shrine of some antiquity stands at the head of a field and a Kéruzh stone at its foot, some ninety paces apart. Nine years ago the shrine's keeper, a woman of the Blue Stream clan whose name I was asked not to set down, complained to the district priestess that the stone was drawing offerings properly the Lady's, the farmers having fallen into the habit of leaving at the foot of the field what they had formerly carried to the head of it. The district priestess found for the shrine and ordered the stone moved to the boundary of the next field, which was done. Within two years the offerings at the shrine had not increased and those at the stone had resumed in its new place, the farmers having simply walked the further distance. The keeper complained a second time. The district priestess, who had by then learned something, declined to hear her.

Every part of this is instructive. The complaint was sincere. The ruling was correct in law and useless in fact. The farmers obeyed it to the letter and defeated it entirely, and not one of them intended any slight to the Lady, whose shrine they went on using for the purposes they had always used it for. A priest who concludes from this that villagers are cunning has taken the wrong lesson away. They were not being cunning.

They were doing two different things, and only the temple supposed the two things to be in competition.

But I have strayed, and at some length, and the reader will have to take the general point from the particular one.

## VII. Whose Aspect Is He?

I come now to the dispute, which the student will hear of soon enough and had better hear of first from someone with no stake in it.

The priests of Lord Durritlámish claim that decay is theirs. They have a case, and it is not a weak one. Among the Greater Aspects of the Cohort stands Bázh Akhár, worshipped in the City of Sáрку and in the Shrines of Quyó in Heméktu, Master of Putrescence and decay, who is powerful among the worms and vermin that dwell beneath the ground and commands them in their legions<sup>4</sup>. Rot is His. The under-earth is His. The worm itself, they will tell you, is His. They will add that the ritual of putrefaction belongs to the Cohort's temple and not to the Lord's, and that in the Kraá Hills it is the Cohort's clans who grow the nuts and fruit the hills are known for, so that if any temple has earned a say in what the soil does, it is theirs. On the face of it there is nothing left for Vráska to hold.

The answer lies in the direction of the work<sup>5</sup>, which is where the answer to most of these disputes lies.

Bázh Akhár presides over the consuming. His face is turned towards the corpse, and His concern is its dissolution: the vermin at their labour, the body going down, the grave earth closing. Where He has finished, there is nothing. Vráska presides over what the earth then does, which is to give it back. His face is turned towards the field. The Aspects are not in competition any more than the mouth competes with the hand. One takes. The other returns. I have tried for some years to put this more memorably and have not managed it. That the same worm serves both is no shame to the doctrine, it is the doctrine.

I will now say the thing that will make me unpopular in two temples at once, and I say it with all due reverence to the gods concerned, whose dispositions are Their own and not ours to arrange.

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Neither temple wants this cult.

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The Inner Temple of Lord Sárku regards the villages as an embarrassment. Its business is the tomb, the rite, the long preparation, the promise held out to those who can pay for it in service and in silence. A stone beside a dung heap is not what they mean by the Worm Lord's dominion, and the priest of the Sixth Circle whose treatise on the Lesser Aspects is otherwise admirable dismisses the whole rural observance in a single sentence, of which more below<sup>6</sup>. The priests of Lord Durritlámish, for their part, are perfectly willing to argue that the doctrine is theirs while making it very clear that the peasants who hold it are not. Their clans in the Kraá Hills own the orchards; the men who keep the stones at the orchard's edge, and the slaves who carry the heap to them, are another matter. Both temples want the jurisdiction. Neither wants the worshippers. I leave the student to name the profession in which this arrangement is unfamiliar.

There is a better reason than distaste, though I have never heard a priest of the Worm give it aloud. Their Lord's Inner Doctrine sets Him against the Stable Cycles of the Lady, and an Aspect that carries the dead back to the furrow looks, from the tomb, very like the Worm doing the Lady's work for Her. I think they are wrong, since nothing goes into the heap and comes out the same, and a round that never returns the same thing twice is Change and not Stability. But the objection is a real one, and it deserves a better answer than the villages can give it.

And here I will permit myself the observation that is proper to my own temple, having held this back since the preface.

The question "to which god does this Aspect belong?" is a question about temples. It is not a question about gods. The gods do not hold offices, do not defer to one another out of duty, and are under no obligation to arrange Themselves in a manner convenient to our arrangement of them. They epitomise what They are. A god does

not follow another's will unless it suits Him, and no god has ever been observed to trouble Himself over whether a scholar at Béy Sú has put Him under the correct heading. The dispute is real, it will be prosecuted with great energy, careers will be made and ended in it, mostly the wrong ones. Change will have the temples and their registers in the end as it has everything else, and the worm will be there when it does. I record this without partiality.

If both temples are correct, what exactly is it that they are disagreeing about?

## VIII. The Three Understandings

The peasant understands Kéruzh as a matter of practice. Manure must be left to mature. Dead vegetation becomes good ground. An animal that dies should not be wasted. A field worked out can be brought back by what the farm itself produces. He is not wrong about any of it.

The priest of Lord Sárku understands Vráska darkly and at a distance. He sees the corpse, the worm, the grave, and the certainty of dissolution, and regards the agricultural use of decay as a small and rather vulgar instance of a far greater truth, which is that all flesh comes at last to his Lord.

The scholar attempts to hold both at once, which is uncomfortable and is meant to be. The dung heap and the grave are not the same thing and the student who says they are has understood nothing. They are the same principle wearing different clothes. I once watched a young priest of the Worm Lord stand at a village heap and name every stage of what was happening inside it, correctly, in the language of the tomb, while the farmer beside him named the same stages in the language of the yard. Neither understood a word the other was saying.

Keep the discomfort. A doctrine made wholesome is no longer the Worm Lord's, and one reduced to corpses has lost the reason half the Empire quietly observes it. What is in the heap is useful, it is necessary, and it stinks. A student who can hold all three of those at once has understood the Aspect. One who cannot will be no use in a farming district.

## IX. Observances

Practice differs by district and by clan, and what follows is common form and not commandment. I count seven. In some districts one or two of the seven are not observed at all, and in the Kraá foothills I was told of an eighth which I could not get anyone to describe twice in the same terms. I give them in the order a man meets them walking out from his door into the yard, which is not the order of their dignity. The student who wishes to rank them by dignity, or by any other method he pleases, may do so in his own time. The farmer does not, and it is the farmer's observance.

The first is the stone itself, of which I have said enough already that little more is needed. It stands near the manure heap, or the composting ground, or the slaughter yard, and where a farm has more than one of these it sometimes has more than one stone. Where it is painted it is painted brown below and white above, with the wavy line and the red daub. Where it is not painted, it is generally because the paint has worn off and nobody has yet got round to it. A stone left unpainted for a generation is not thereby abandoned. I asked about this at several villages and was looked at as though I had asked whether a house was abandoned because the door wanted mending.

The second belongs to the spreading. When mature dung is first carried out to a field in the season, a short acknowledgement is made to Kéruzh, generally by the head of the household and generally in fewer words than a priest would think decent. Where a prayer has been offered to the Lady at the sowing, this one follows it and does not replace it. I have heard it said at the field's edge while the slaves stood waiting with the baskets, and I have heard it said afterwards over the evening meal. Once I heard it forgotten altogether and made good the next morning with an apology, which I took for better evidence of its meaning than any amount of recitation.

The third concerns the beasts. A chlén or hmá that dies of itself, of age or of sickness and not by the knife, is returned to the earth with a word to the Worm Lord rather than left for the birds. Where the beast died of a sickness the farmer fears, it is buried deeper and the word is longer. I make no comment on the husbandry, which is sound, except to note that the village has arrived by its own road at a precaution the physicians of Lord Keténgku charge a great deal to recommend.

The fourth is kept at the slaughter yard, where the waste is treated as a return and not as rubbish, and is not thrown into a watercourse. In districts where it is thrown into a watercourse, the priest has other problems, and I have found him on the whole unwilling to hear about them from me.

With the fifth we come to bone and ash, which are worked into the ground wherever local practice finds it useful, with the understanding that these are the White Gift. Practice differs here more than anywhere. At one village near Púrdimal the bones are broken with a stone kept for that purpose and no other. At the next they are burned first. At a third I was told that bone was never put on the fields at all, and was then shown the fields, where there was bone in every furrow.

The sixth is the copper. A little is pressed into the earth at the foot of the stone by the pious and taken up again, within a day or two, by the poor. Nobody pretends it stays there. I once heard a village priestess of the Lady tell a farmer that this made the offering worthless, and heard him answer that copper had never stayed anywhere in his experience and he did not see why the god should expect it to. I could not have put the doctrine of my own temple more briefly, and I have tried.

The seventh is not an act but an admonition, and it is the one the old repeat to children and to newly bought slaves: that nothing is to be wasted merely because it has stopped being useful in the shape it had.

The last is the most nearly ours of the seven. A thing is called waste when it has stopped being useful to the man looking at it, which tells you much about the man and nothing at all about the thing. The universe keeps no such category.

A student who recites these seven at a farmer as though they were liturgy deserves what he will get, which is a basket and a morning at the heap.

## **X. Objections**

At Béy Sú it is the custom, when a treatise is read before the Circle, that those present put their objections in form, that the author rise to answer each in form, and that the whole be written down by a junior priest who is not permitted to comment. This treatise has not been read before the Circle. I have asked twice. I have therefore

put the objections myself, and in fairness I have put each in the mouth of the person who actually made it to me, together with their standing, so that the student may weigh the objector as well as the objection, which is how it is done in practice whatever the schools pretend. Where I was asked not to give a name I have given the office. There are seven. The student may omit none of them, but he need fear only the third.

The first objection is put by the Lady Arlúa hiVréshcha, of the Seventh Circle of the Temple of Avánthe, who keeps the Lady's shrine at the West Gate of Tsurú. She says: *"This Aspect brings the Lord of Worms too near to the Mistress of Heaven. The field is Hers, and the round of the seasons is Hers from sowing to sowing, and a god who is honoured at the field's foot in the same hour as She is honoured at its head is being made a partner in Her work."*

To her I answer thus. I have conceded already, and gladly, that Vráska is no god of fertility, and I concede it again here so that it cannot be said I conceded it only once. But the round of the seasons is a round only when it is looked at from the Lady's side. Seen from the heap it has a second half, in which nothing grows and a great deal happens, and the Lady's priests have never claimed that half, nor wished to. He does not germinate the seed. He has charge of the passage of matter out of one condition into another, and on that passage the Lady's own doctrine is silent. I will add, since the Lady Arlúa is fond of the old authorities, that the commentator whom the schools call the Grey Hand raised the same objection in the time of the Engsvanyáli priest-kings, and was answered, and that his work now survives only in the answers. It is not a fate I would wish upon her.

The second objection is put by the priests of Lord Durritlámish at Púrdimal, collectively, in four letters and on two occasions in person, the second of them in a corridor. They say: *"Decay belongs to Lord Durritlámish by way of His Aspect Bázh Akhár, and the Lord of Worms has no need of a second custodian for what His Cohort already holds."*

I have answered this at length in the seventh section, and four times by letter, and the answer has not changed on any of the six occasions. The consuming is the Cohort's.

The returning is the Lord's. Those who wish to press the point further will find me at Béy Sú, where I will be glad of the argument, and gladder still if it is a new one.

The third objection I did not hear from an opponent. It was put to me by Mnéktu hiTurushán of the Domed Tomb, a ritual priest of the Fifth Circle of the Temple of Lord Sáрку at Púrdimal, whom I have known since we were both young enough to think such questions could be settled in an evening. He has since gone down into the tombs beneath the City of Sáрку, and whether he went there as the elect go I have not been told and have not asked. I set the objection down as he put it, and I lay aside the form for it, since he never cared for the form and would think it a poor way to be remembered. He put it so: *"If Lord Sáрку promises that His faithful shall endure beyond the grave, why does His Aspect teach that all things return to the earth?"*

This is the serious objection and the student should treat it with respect, for it goes to the heart of what draws men to the Worm Lord in the first place. The promise is real: a body that endures, a mind that perceives, a will that persists. It is the oldest wish our race has and no other god offers it.

But observe what the promise costs and to whom it is offered. It is not the common lot. It is bought with service, with secrecy, with rites of great length and expense, and it is granted to few. Every stage of it is a work against the grain of things. Bones must be gathered and made whole again before they will serve. The preserved body must be tended. Nothing about it happens of itself, and everything about it must be maintained.

Now consider Vráska, who requires no rite, no payment, no priest, and no consent, and who is therefore the one Aspect of the Worm Lord whom a slave and a prince approach upon precisely the same terms. He has charge of everything the great promise does not claim, which is to say the fallen leaf, the slaughtered beast, the harvest stubble, and all the unremembered dead of every village in the Empire. Ha'ótl of the Tattered Shroud sees the poor into the ground; what the ground does with them afterwards is Vráska's. He does not need to be invoked to act. He acts.

I will put it as plainly as I may without discourtesy to a fellow god of our Dark Trinity. An exemption purchased at such cost is the strongest evidence available that

the rule it exempts you from is absolute. The Worm Lord's elect do not disprove Vráska. They are the reason we can see him clearly.

Mnéktu did not accept this. He said I had described the rule very well and the exemption very poorly, since the Worm Lord has never promised that the body escapes the worm, only that the mind need not leave it. The flesh of the elect goes down like anyone's, only more slowly, and what is kept is the hlákme. It did not occur to me until he had gone into the tombs that he had given me the better half of my own argument. The student should not go into a village without an answer to this objection, and he is welcome to find a better one than mine.

The fourth objection is put by the Most Learned Garúesh hiNeshkúmu, of the Ninth Circle of my own temple at Béy Sú, who was raised to that Circle in the year that I was not, and whose lectures on the Doctrine of Unreality I have attended with the greatest regularity. He says, and has said to the students of three successive years: *"The worship of painted stones beside dung heaps is simple and ignoble peasant superstition, and a scholar of Lord Hrü'ú who spends his leave upon it has mistaken village custom for the working of Change."*

To him I answer thus, and with the respect his Circle requires. Some of it is superstition. I have been shown a stone in the Kraá foothills which the village swore was a Kéruzh shrine and which was plainly a boundary marker of the Engsvanyáli period with a face on it. I have been shown another which was a millstone, painted, in fairness to the village, very carefully. Superstition in the practice does not establish falsehood in the principle, and separating the two is a large part of what temple scholarship is for. I would remind the Most Learned Garúesh, should he ever read this far, that it is his own teaching, in the fourth of his lectures on Unreality, that a scholar who has declined to examine a thing has no standing to call it unreal. I took this down at the time. I have it still.

The fifth objection was put to me by a student of my own, in his second year, whose name I withhold because he has since improved. He said: *"If everything returns, then death is no tragedy, and the mourners at a graveside are merely mistaken about what has happened."*

I answered him at the time at greater length than he wanted, and I answer him here more briefly. No. Change does not cancel loss. The man who has died is not given back because matter from his body has entered another process, and the Báletl that was his has gone where Lord Belkhánu takes it and is not in the field. Grief is the fifth of the Fivefold and belongs where it stands. No theology will argue a man out of it, and one that claims it can has stopped describing the world and taken up consolation, which is Lord Belkhánu's office and not ours. The student wrote this down. I am told he now teaches it at Sokátis, under another man's name.

The sixth was not put in any school. It was put to me at dinner in Béy Sú, between the fish and the sweet, by a lady of a high clan who was paying for the fish. "*Why*," she asked, "*should anyone honour anything so unpleasant?*"

I answered her at the table, and I answer her here in the same words, which did not please her then either. Because pleasantness has never been the measure of importance. The physician works in blood, the midwife in worse, the tomb-servant in what you would rather not hear described, and the farmer in dung. None of their subjects is made small by being disagreeable.

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A theology that attends only to  
what is fragrant will be a short one.

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I was not asked again.

The seventh and last came in writing, from the office of the Warden of the Schools in the Palace of the Priesthoods, and was the whole of the reply to a memorandum of mine which I mention below. It read, in its entirety: "*Why should the temples trouble themselves with a rural Aspect?*" It was not signed.

Because the Empire eats. Because the clans of the plough are also clans of the Worm Lord in half the northern provinces, and a priest who does not know what is on the

stone at the end of their field will be governing people he does not understand. And because the antiquity and the spread of the thing make it worth a scholar's time on their own account, which ought to be reason enough and rarely is. I sent this answer to the Warden's office in the following month. It, too, was acknowledged.

## **XI. What I Propose**

I do not propose that villages build great temples to Vráska. They would not, and the proposal would confound everyone. Nor do I propose that the Aspect be raised above his rank. Lesser does not mean false; nor common, trivial.

What I propose is that the observance be taught in the temple schools as what it is: a genuine expression of Lord Sárku's doctrine, held by people of no standing, under the usual disciplines. The reasons are practical before they are theological. A priest who knows what his farmers believe will not mistake their customs for ignorance. And there is a scholarly reason as well, which is that a doctrine this old and this widespread is worth study whether or not anyone at Báy Súi finds it dignified. I set the case out at greater length in a memorandum to the Warden of the Schools in the Palace of the Priesthoods some years ago, which was acknowledged.

We are inclined to assume that instruction travels downward from the temple to the village. In this instance the traffic has gone the other way. Generations of farmers watched the earth change, gave the change a name, and marked the stone with the right sign without anyone from the Inner Circles telling them what it was. Our part in the business has been to arrive late and argue about the filing.

## XII. Propositions for the Student

These ten are to be held in memory, in the manner of the schools, and given when asked for. A student who can give them in order has satisfied his examiner. One who can give them in any order and still say why each stands where it does has understood them, which is harder and is not examined.

1. Vráska, Lord of Blood and Bone, called also He Who Returns All Things, is a Lesser Aspect of Lord Sáрку.
2. In the villages of central and northern Tsolyánu he is Kéruzh, the Worm-Eaten Earth.
3. His concern is the return and transformation of what has lived. It is not fertility.
4. The Lady has charge of growth. The Báletl belongs to Lord Belkhánu and Lord Qón. Vráska has charge of the matter that is left, and of nothing else.
5. The corpse, the heap, the dung pile, and the fallen crop are four appearances of one process.
6. The Five Gifts are a teaching scheme. Four are given by us. The fifth is returned to us, and the epithet follows from that.
7. The claim of the adepts of Lord Durritlámish is serious and is answered by direction of work, not by volume of assertion.
8. The promise of endurance made to the Worm Lord's elect does not contradict this Aspect. It measures him.
9. The darkness is not to be filed off to make the doctrine agreeable.
10. What has stopped being useful in one shape may be useful in another. This is Change and not annihilation.

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A student who has learned these  
ten and still will not put his hand in  
the heap has learned nine.

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### **For the Examining Priest**

What follows is for the examiner and not for the student, who will read it anyway. I set it down against the day this treatise is set for the examination of the Third Circle at Béy Sú, or anywhere else. I do not expect to see that day. The examiner who uses these notes may therefore take them as coming from the dead, which in a treatise upon this Aspect seems to me fitting.

On marking. The schools at Béy Sú know three results: the pass, the distinction, and the return, which is what the schools call it when a student is sent back to begin his year again. I have always thought the last the most honest of the three, and it is the only one this Aspect would recognise. A student who gives the ten and can do nothing further with them has done what the junior priest does who writes down the disputations: he has been accurate and is not permitted to comment. He should pass and no more. A student who can illustrate the seventh proposition from his own district rather than from this treatise, or who meets the difficulty of the Brown Gift without being led to it, has earned more than a bare pass, and the examiner should say so in the record. The distinction is for one who gives an answer to the third objection that differs from mine and is not worse. It is rarer than it should be, and the examiner should not withhold it merely because the answer is unfamiliar to him. A student of our own temple who observes, unprompted, that the dispute between the temples is itself subject to Change should be given credit. One who observes it at length should be given less.

On errors. There are four the examiner will meet in almost every year. The first is the Green Error, that Vráska is a god of fertility. It is common and understandable, and it is to be corrected firmly, since a student who carries it into a village will carry it next into an argument with a priestess of the Lady, and lose. The second is the grandmother's error, that the Worm Lord takes the Báletl. It is to be corrected, and the student asked where he heard it. The answer is generally instructive. The third is that the dung heap and the grave are the same thing. A student who says so has understood half of the eighth section and should be sent back to the other half. The fourth is the correspondence of the Five Gifts to the Fivefold. I have no authority to call it an error in doctrine and do not. It is an error in method, and the examiner may mark it as such, particularly if the student has plainly copied it off a wall.

There is a fifth position which I hold to be an error and which the examiner is advised not to mark as one: that Kéruzh is Bázh Akhár under a country name, of which see the fifth note. It is held by persons of standing in the Temple of Lord Durrítlámish, and by at least one examiner I could name. A student should not be returned for holding what his examiner's superior holds. I say this without bitterness, having not been examined myself for some years.

On questions. The examiner may set the following to learn whether the ten have been understood or merely held. The Barber's Question, from the first section, which the schools at Thri'il have made famous and may keep. The Question of the Poison Days, from the fourth, to which the right answer is a better question. And the Stonemason's Question, which I have not set out in this treatise and give here for the examiner's use alone: when the Kéruzh stone has itself weathered to grit and gone into the heap, to whom has it returned? A student who answers promptly has not understood it. One who says he does not know, and then says what he would need to know, should pass.

On what is not to be examined. Two matters are closed. The first is the practice of the Worm Lord's elect: what they undergo in the tombs, and what they become. This treatise makes no claim upon those mysteries and neither should the examiner. If a student shows that he knows more of them than a student ought, he is not to be asked how he knows, and the examiner would do well to find that he has somewhere else to be. The second is any argument that because all things return, the promise made to the elect is false. A student who begins upon this is to be stopped before he has finished the sentence. It is blasphemy against a god of our Dark Trinity and not a matter for marks. The Temple of Lord Sáрку has a long memory, and it is the examiner who will be asked why it was said in his room.

## Authors Notes

<sup>1</sup> The numbering is that used at Púrdimal and in the temple schools of the City of Sárku, where the Lesser Aspects are reckoned in a continuous sequence after the ten Greater. The Temple acknowledges a hundred and eight in all, but only the Greater must have a shrine in every major temple and only the Lesser are recognised by all of them. The rest are local, or archaic, or kept to the Inner Temple, or still argued over between its factions, and it is a fair question which of these Vráska is. The Púrdimal schools have answered it by giving him a number. It is not universal. The schools at Béy Sú count several of the northern Aspects in a different order and place this one at sixty-one; Thri'íl numbers only the Greater and leaves the rest to be known by name, which has the advantage of ending the argument and the disadvantage of ending it in the wrong place. The oldest register I have seen, a Bednálljan fragment kept at Mekú, numbers nothing at all and lists the Aspects by the colour of their offerings. I mention it so that no student supposes the argument is new, or that it will end. I have used the Púrdimal reckoning throughout because it is the one I learned. A student should state which reckoning he is using, once, and then decline to discuss it.

<sup>2</sup> I have been of the Eighth Circle for eleven years. I mention it not by way of complaint. Advancement is decided by men who have their own reasons and are under no obligation to share them, and a scholar who cannot bear to be passed over has mistaken his profession and would do better selling amulets in the bazaar. I will add only that Lord Hrü'ü teaches that no arrangement is permanent, and that I have found the doctrine a considerable comfort.

<sup>3</sup> The name is stable across a surprising distance, which is itself worth a scholar's attention. Local variants I have recorded include Kérush and, at two villages only, Kéruzhal. I have twice been told the name meant something in the old speech of the district, once "*he who waits underneath*" and once "*the slow mouth*", and on both occasions the next village along gave me a different meaning. *The Glosses of Qurén the Younger* derive it from an Engsvanyáli word for a grave-digger, on no evidence I have been able to find. Qurén had not, so far as I can learn, ever been further north than Jakállá.

<sup>4</sup> *The Book of Tenebrous Places* is the text the Cohort's priests cite here, and *The Five-Sided Tome of the Putrescent One* the text with which the Worm Lord's priests

reply. I recommend both be read before arguing with anyone who has. I read the second at the City of Sáрку in my third year there, in the Tsolyáni rendering kept for visitors, the original being in the Tongue of the Lord of Worms, which no one outside the Inner Circles is taught. I was permitted to hold it for one afternoon under the eye of a priest who did not, in all that time, blink. It is not a work I find congenial and it is not meant to be congenial.

<sup>5</sup> It has been put to me, by the priests of Lord Durritlámish at Púrdimal and separately, with better manners, by a village priestess of the Lady, that Kéruzh may be no Aspect at all, but a village name for the Worm Lord Himself, or for Bázh Akhár in a country dialect. I have considered this and do not accept it. The distinction is plain to anyone who has stood at a heap and at a graveside in the same week, and I decline to argue it further with men who have done neither.

<sup>6</sup> I decline to name him. He is living, he is irritable, and his treatise is in other respects the best thing written on the Lesser Aspects in forty years, which makes the single dismissive sentence more irritating rather than less. It is known in the schools by the colour of its binding, and those who need to know which book I mean already do.

## Appendix: Names and Epithets

**Formal temple name:** Vráska, Lord of Blood and Bone

**Principal epithet:** He Who Returns All Things

**Common name in the villages of central and northern Tsolyánu:** Kéruzh, the Worm-Eaten Earth

**Other epithets recorded:** The Worm Beneath the Furrow; Keeper of the Black Gift; Feeder of Roots; the Patient Guest (Kraá foothills, rare)

**Colours:** brown below, white above, after the Worm Lord's own

**Sign:** the wavy line with the red daub, as Lord Sárku's

A caution on all of the above. These names and orderings are not universal and were never meant to be. Local cults use other names, other epithets, and other forms, and several of them are older than anything written here. The purpose of this treatise is to give the student something to compare against. It is not to tidy the Empire.

### {Added in a later hand, on the reverse of the final leaf:}

Copied at Khirgár in the spring of 2377. The Kusijáktodali died of a flux in 2352, still of the Eighth Circle. Neither the Temple of Sárku nor that of Durrítlámish has ever answered the treatise. The Black Earth Clan, once visited by the author, have kept a shrine to Kéruzh these twenty years and will not be told that they invented him.

### {Below, in a third hand:}

Copied again at Khirgár in the spring of 2389, at the request of Dlæssuna hiTlakotáni, for her kinsman Hejjéka hiTlakotáni, Vintner and Lord of The Springs of Jorjuka. The note above is set down as it stood in the exemplar.

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